

primary component for gaming, and upgrading it will yield the biggest performance hike

2. Processor: Your CPU feeds your GPU with data. The faster the CPU, the faster the GPU will work
3. Memory: if have less than 1 GB, then upgrading your memory to 2 GB can give you a boost of around 40 per cent!

If you are not very discerning about how good your game looks, then a mid-range, Rs 8,000 graphics card will get you through easily. Discerning gamers who want to play the latest games in all their visual splendour will need to keep a budget of around Rs 15,000 for a good card. I recommend NVIDIA's 8800GT-based card (Rs 13,000) to the discerning gamer, and NVIDIA's 8600GT core (Rs 7,500) to the more budget-minded. For the extreme gamer who wants to run games at very high resolutions with all the visual settings kept at maximum, a single graphics card may not suffice. But for the simple reason that PCs get outdated so fast, I don't recommend investing in an SLI or Crossfire (multiple graphics cards) setup.

The second component you need to inspect is your CPU. The faster the clock speeds, the more frames per second you will get in any game. Intel's latest 45 nm Penryn processors (codenamed Wolfdale) are just out. The Wolfdale E8400 which runs at a speedy 3.0 GHz, is priced at just under the Rs 10,000 mark, and is an excellent solution for gamers. In fact, this processor is a killer deal for any kind of fast PC, and I heartily recommend it. If you must have something cheaper, Intel's older 65 nm Core 2 Duo based E6750 (2.66 GHz) is available for Rs 7,900. Quad-core processors are also available, but the two additional cores don't do much for gaming, since most games are heavily single-threaded. The cheapest quad-core is Intel's Core 2 Quad 6600, a 65 nm, 2.4 GHz chip (Rs 11,000). As for memory, opt for a minimum of 2 GB of DDR2 system memory—its dirt cheap these days at Rs 900 per GB—and you're set to go as far as your PC's performance goes. Look for good brands like Transcend, Kingston, and Corsair.

But wait...the devil is in the details, right? A good monitor is essential to get the best out of premium components, and these days the name of the game is widescreen LCD. A 22-inch widescreen LCD will sport a native resolution of 1680 x 1050 pixels, and should cost around Rs 15,000. 24-inch TN panels are in the realm of 19,000 bucks and I feel this is superb value for money. Brands to look out for are Dell, ViewSonic, AOC, Acer, BenQ, Samsung and LG.

Keep in mind that these recommendations are generic, and certain genres of games will run easily on even lower-end hardware. Games like racing games and adventure games (in general) are not as harsh on system requirements as other genres, although there is no hard and fast rule.

Consoles: Single Minded Purpose

Consoles are broadly of different types and the term *console* is used to signify that the gaming station is a device other than a PC. Even the Sony PSP—a tiny



handheld device—is a console in the strict sense of the word. Over the past two years, we've seen a lot of developments in the world of consoles. One serious advantage over the PC remains that consoles are designed keeping games and game developers in mind, and it takes a console a couple of years to mature and to get proper development support. After all, what good is a shiny new, powerful console with no games to play? The PS2, for example, was released in the year 2000, and still enjoys a much larger fan following than the PS3. In fact, it was a

title that was released much later that actually sold the PS2—*God of War*. Even the X360 experienced a tremendous boost in sales with the release of *Gears of War*—a third person shooter that was launched a year after the console. Whereas you would have undoubtedly had to upgrade your PC a number of times from 2001 to 2007 to play games, and spent more than a lakh on components, if you had a console like the PS2, chances are you'd still be enjoying the experience. In fact, the best titles for any console tend to release at least two

or three years after the console is launched, that being the period of time it takes developers to churn out a good game.

The X360 is in no way a mature platform. Sure, it has some great titles, like *Gears Of War*, *The Elder Scrolls 4: Oblivion* and *Mass Effect*, but the best is yet to come. In fact, I remember when the Xbox came out, Microsoft only had a single big title for it—*Halo*. Consoles also cannot be modified to improve performance and parts can't be swapped out like a PC, so a developer has to think of the hardware of the console and its limitations when he writes code. With a PC, on the other hand, most developers know that they can design something a little heavier than what current generation hardware can run comfortably, and manufacturers like NVIDIA, ATI, Intel and AMD will just go back to their drawing boards and design

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something more powerful. So when you go with a console, you needn't think about future-proofing.

The Hidden Costs

So then, a console seems to have all the answers. Why not buy an X360 for Rs 20,000, instead of a PC which costs Rs 50,000, and which you have to upgrade repeatedly? There's a pit-fall to consoles too. Most consoles have anti-piracy measures built in and so do the game titles, but unlike PCs where you can have cracks and registry editors, you must have the original game DVD in your drive before you can start playing on a console. If you're like a bowling ball at an arcade with game titles you're going to chalk up quite a bill, especially considering new titles for the latest consoles (X360, PS3) can cost as much as Rs 3,000. While this doesn't mean that you should buy a PC just so that you can play pirated games, PC titles are generally more varied than console titles, and tend to cost less, and you also get special editions where you can buy an entire series in a single box for much less than the individual titles.

Most people who buy an X360 use their TVs to play games, and then complain "man, the graphics suck!" And why not? Consoles like the X360 and PS3 have been designed with a resolution of 720p (1280x720 pixels) in mind—a regular television cannot even hope to meet that specification, and you the image you see is blurry, lacks colour, resolution and even detail. An additional cost which you *should* incur is to buy yourself an LCD / Plasma screen to go along with the console—this is really where a console will earn its stripes and the experience will be enjoyable and immersive.

For a viewing distance of around 10-12 feet, a 32-inch LCD should do the trick. Brands to look out for are Sony, Samsung, and LG. If you have a larger living room then go for a bigger screen, since chances are you'll be sitting further away, and remember that such a screen, in addition to your console, makes for a killer movie-theatre like experience.

In fact both Microsoft and Sony have gone through pains to ensure that their consoles are more than just gaming stations. The X360 is a full fledged HD-DVD player, while the PS3 comes with a Blu-Ray DVD drive. This kind of future proofing ensures that your console is ready for the next generation of content, although on a minus point such drives do increase prices.

What To Consider

Consoles use controllers to interface with them. Some of them are wireless, which give you the liberty to sit far away from your screen without having a clutter of cables. Both the X360 and the PS3 have such controllers, while other consoles like the Nintendo Wii (pronounced "we") has a special remote control unit that makes use of built in accelerometers and gyroscopes as well as infrared tracking to make use of user gestures and actions to control actions in a game, as well as the traditional



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button system. But really, it's titles that sell consoles; the only point of difference that matters to the user is applications—in this case, games.

So what games feel better on the controllers of a console? Well the most convenient candidates are arcade fighters and hack-em-up games that require a lot of frantic key presses (called button mashing) to execute combo moves, or use special powers. Accessories like racing wheels are also available for consoles as

they are for PCs, and racing games on a console have the added advantage of being played on a larger screen as opposed to your PC's monitor.

The next thing you need to look at is the present and upcoming crop of game titles for each console. This is very important, because unlike a PC which can be used for many things other than gaming, you don't want to be stuck with a console that hasn't got adequate title support. Garnering developer support is important—more game developers developing for your console equals better games. Development studios have been taken over (a so called forceful conversion) and we're even seeing developers who are working on titles for both consoles. Franchisees change hands too—we've seen *Devil May Cry 4* being announced for the X360 as well as the PS3, previously this franchisee was a Sony exclusive.

The PS3 doesn't have many noteworthy titles to speak of—in fact, *God Of War 2* (the sequel to the best-selling *God of War*) was announced for the PS2 and not the PS3, which clearly proves the point I was making about the longevity of a console as compared to a PC. That aside, the PS3 is a very strong contender for your attention, especially considering that most of its big titles are scheduled for 2008 launches. However, the PS3 makes a costly proposition and costs 60 per cent more than an Xbox 360.

Microsoft has another distinct advantage when it comes to the X360—they have very strong roots in PC gaming, where their Windows rules supreme as a gaming platform. It's a simple matter, therefore, to approach developers to develop games for their console platform as well, or even release X360 versions of PC classics. We're seeing games like *Universe at War: Earth Assault*, *Rainbow Six: Vegas*, and *Fallout 3* all heading for the X360 as well. The reverse is also true, and many Xbox / X360 titles make their way into PC—*Gears Of War*, *Halo*, and *Jade Empire* are a few examples.

In Retrospect

Regardless of how much you spend, the hardware you use, the platform you choose, or even the genres of your taste—the main aim of games is to have fun. They involve us, pull us into a world where anything is possible, and you're at the centre of it. You get to control events around you...playing God can be fun! Games in moderation will benefit your thinking, and can even have effects like lowering stress levels, or even improving hand-eye coordination. You're never too young or too busy to start, and it's never too late to get into it. As for me, I'm gearing up for our next *Quake 3* session which begins in another 15 minutes...■

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